

Dissertation proposal, the meme cut

WHAT IS A PROMPT?

A language-game.





THE ANOMALY

The same four words do different work depending on the game they are played in.

ME: “The prompt is an operative description situated between natural language, programming, legal instruction, and performance.”

MODEL: “Sir, you asked for a yellow circle.”



The theory is long. The request was short.

The distance between those two lines is the subject of this talk.

The yellow circle comes from the p5.js tutorial the project started with.

PROMPT: "Draw a circle."

1. SVG

```
<circle cx="50"  
cy="50" r="40"/>
```

2. ASCII

```
  * * * * *  
 *           *  
*             *  
*             *  
*             *  
 *           *  
  * * * * *
```

3. DIFFUSION



4. TURTLE

```
REPEAT 360 [  
  FORWARD 1  
  RIGHT 1 ]
```



**SAME FOUR TOKENS.
CORRECT IN ONE GAME. WRONG IN THE OTHER THREE.**

**One sentence gets four
correct answers.**

SVG, ASCII, diffusion and turtle
graphics each satisfy "Draw a
circle." Each is wrong in the other
three games.

QUALIFYING EXAM — SECTION 2

Name: _____

7. “Draw a circle.” is:

- (a) an order
- (b) a unit test
- (c) a score
- (d) a dare
- (e) a benchmark
- (f) an opening move in a negotiation over geometry
- (g) depends what happens next

READ THEM AND YOU CANNOT TELL. PLAY THEM AND YOU CAN.

**Reading the sentence
does not settle which
act it is.**

An order, a unit test, a score, a dare.
You learn which one it was from
what happens next.

Austin (1962) classifies an utterance once. This project stages the game and watches the class change on a numbered turn.

THE SAME PROMPT

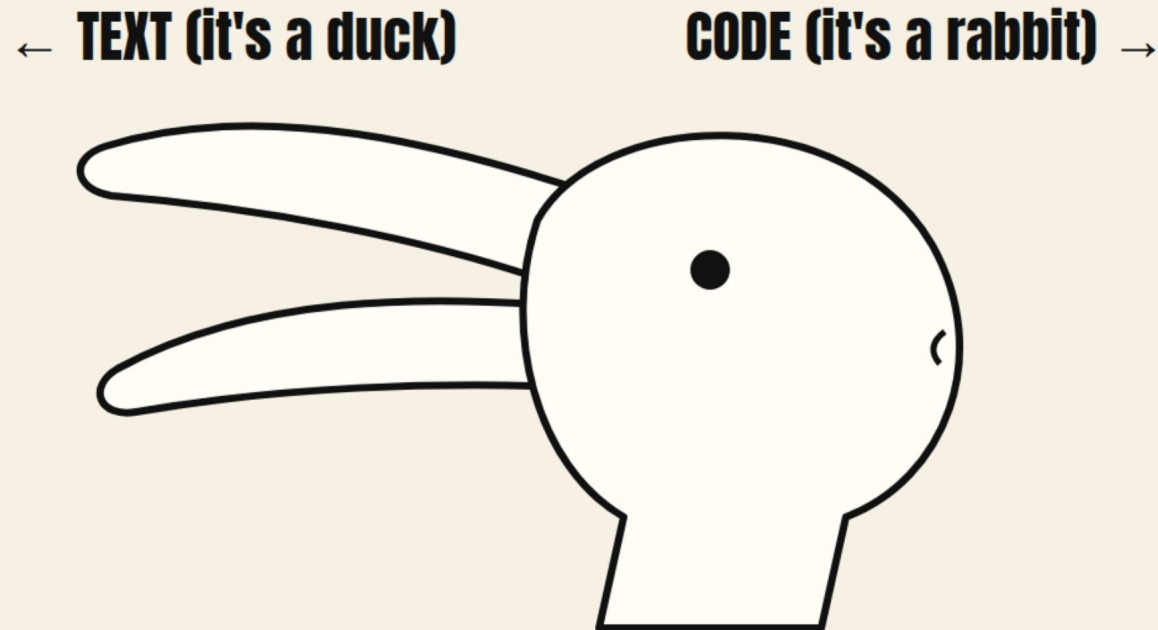
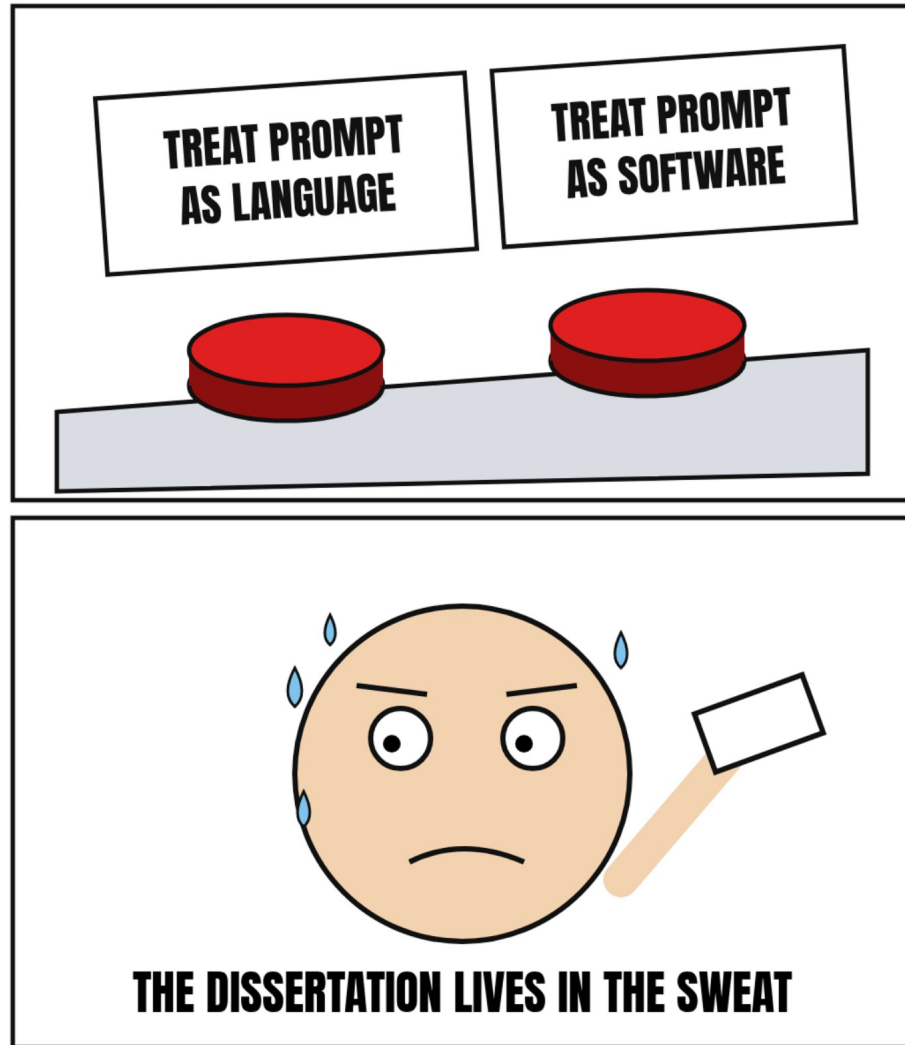


Fig. 1. Aspect-seeing. You cannot see both at once, and the model does not care which.

**A prompt is seen as text
or as code, not both
at once.**

The drawing does not change. The aspect does.

Wittgenstein, *Philosophical Investigations*, Part II, xi.



Each discipline is asked to choose one reading.

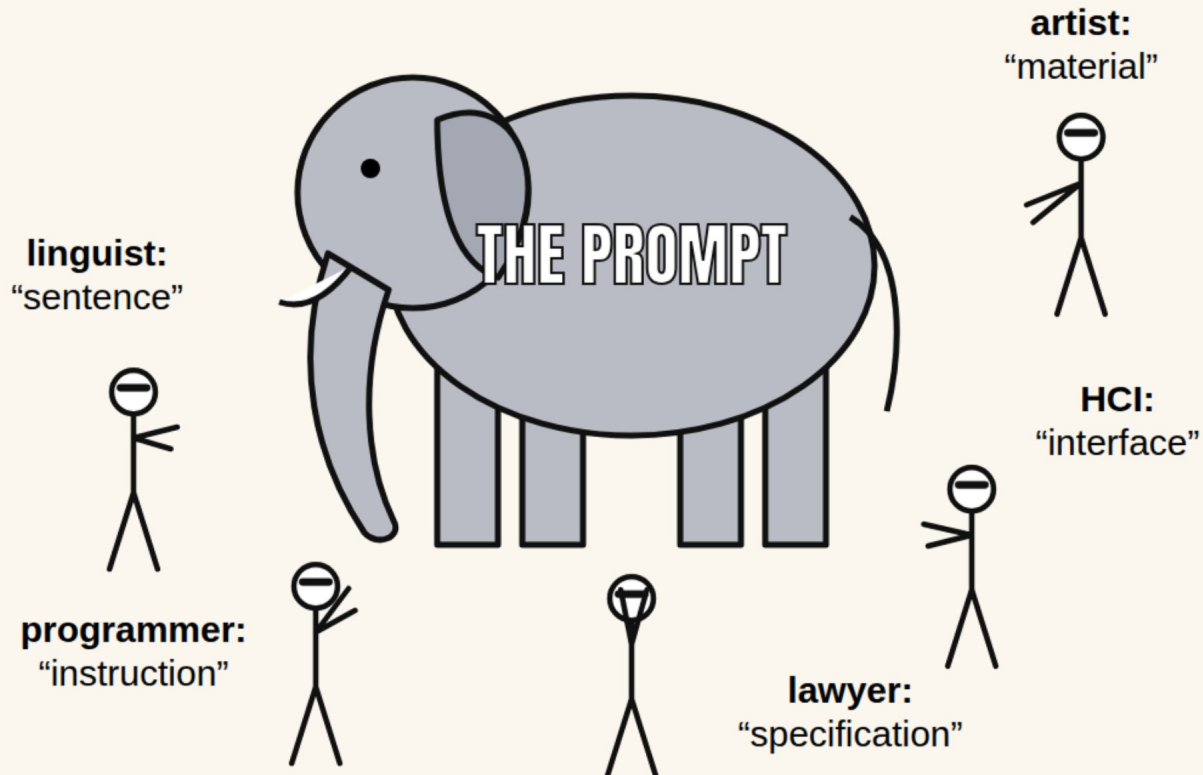
Treat it as language and the execution drops out. Treat it as software and the situation drops out.



THE WRONG UNIT

"Prompt" may be a category mistake produced by an interface.

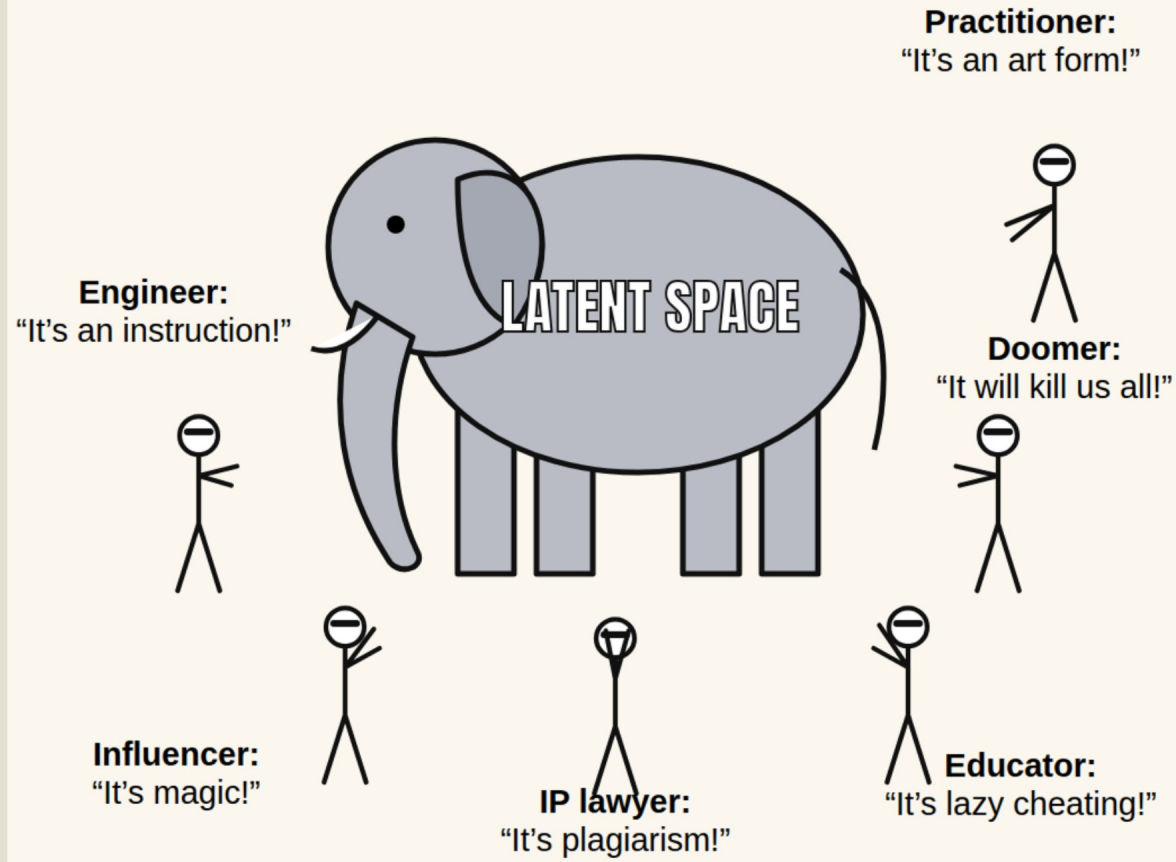
WHAT IS A PROMPT?



Five fields describe the part they touch.

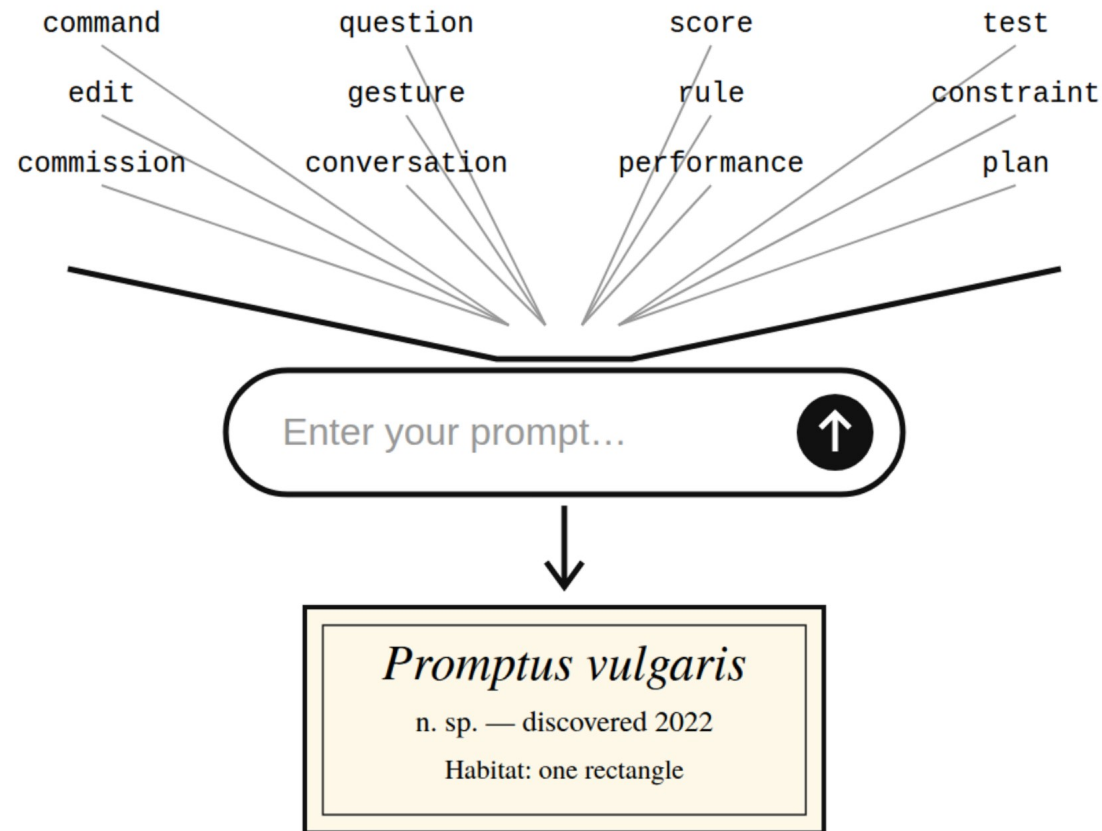
Sentence, instruction, specification, interface, material. All correct, none sufficient.

THE ELEPHANT IN THE ROOM



Public talk about AI does the same thing.

Instruction, magic, plagiarism, cheating, doom, art form. What sits underneath is not visible from any one position.

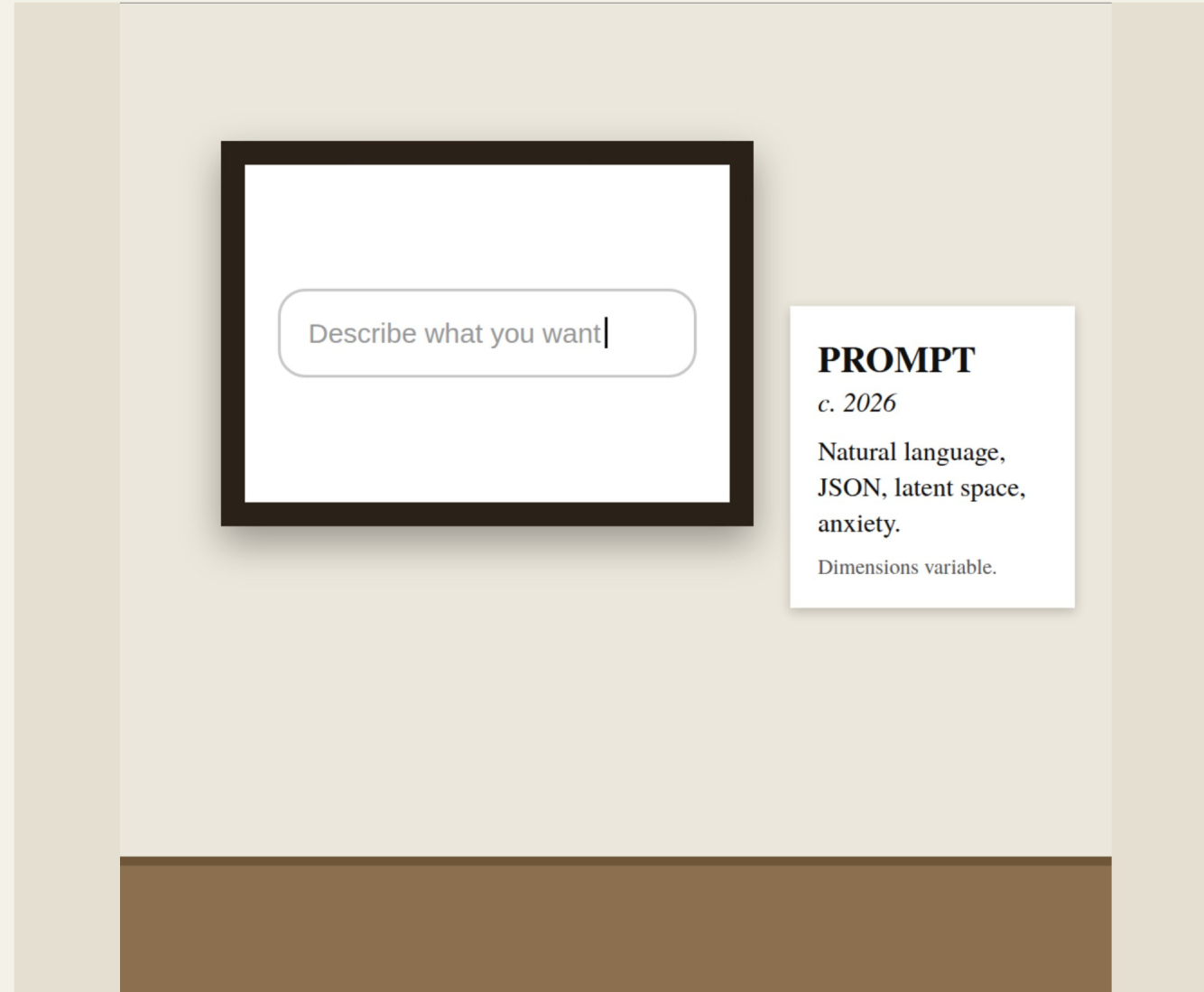


**TWELVE PRACTICES ENTER ONE RECTANGLE
AND COME OUT LOOKING LIKE A SPECIES**

Twelve practices pass through one rectangle.

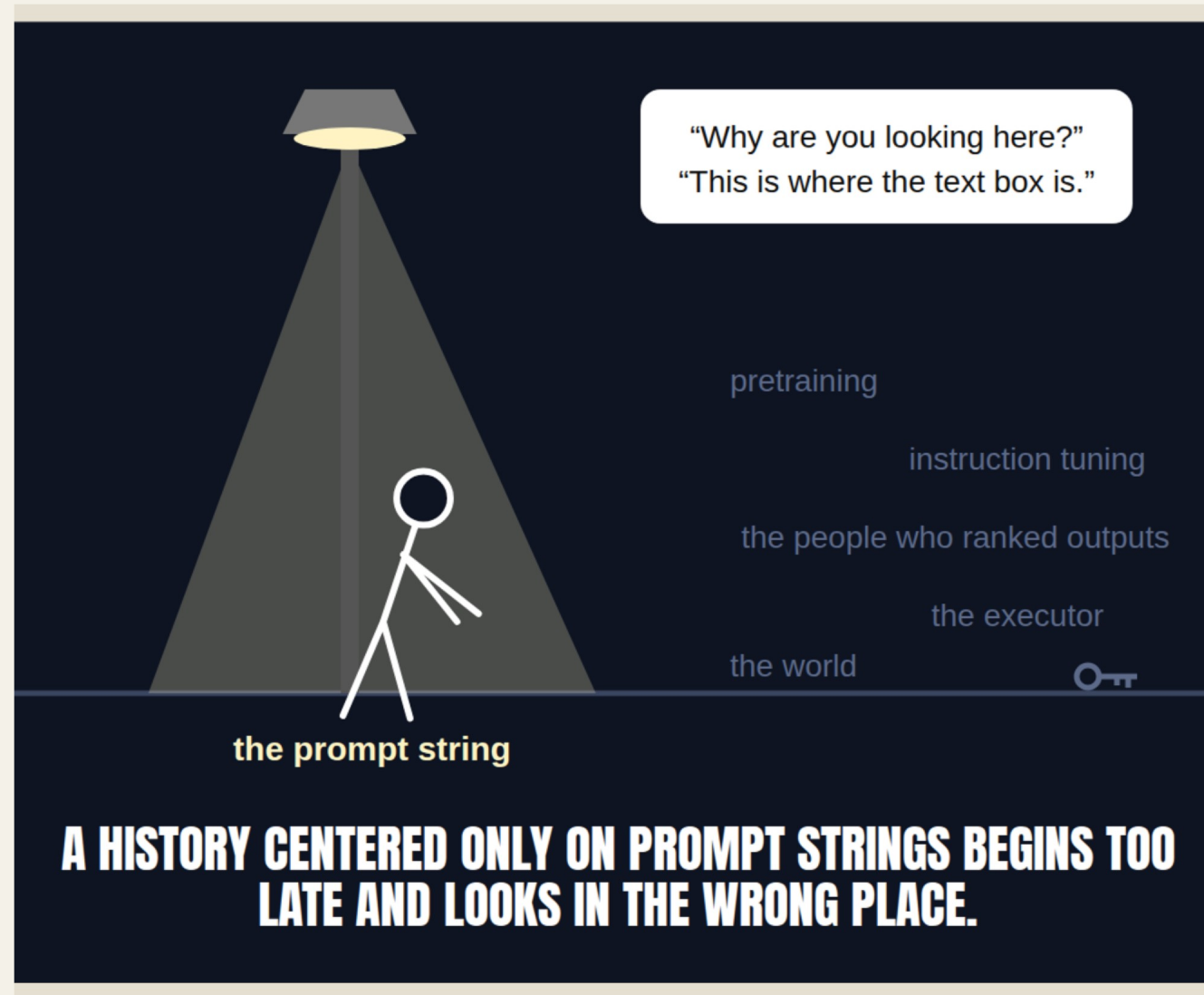
Command, question, score, test, edit, gesture and six more enter one text box and come out looking like a single species.

Ryle on category mistakes. Proposal deck, slide 03: the claim.



**As an object, a prompt
explains very little.**

Natural language, JSON, latent
space, anxiety. Dimensions variable.

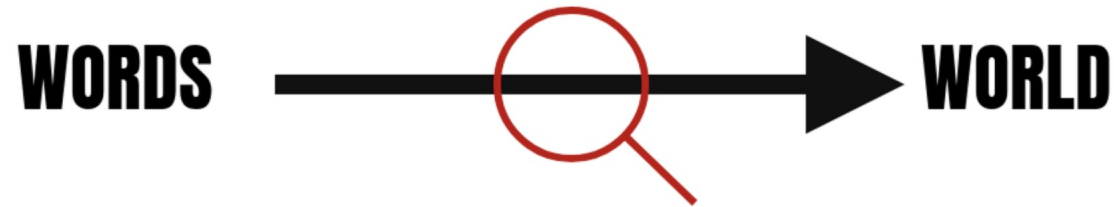


Histories of prompting look where the text box is.

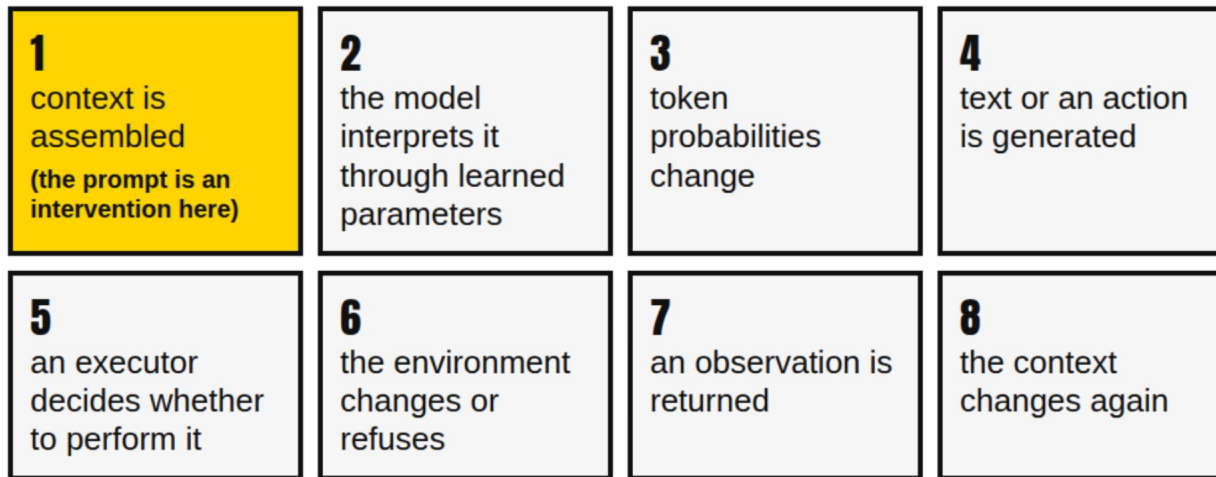
Pretraining, instruction tuning, the people who ranked outputs, the executor and the world all sit outside the light.

"The Prompt Does Not Act Alone," conclusion.

WORDS GO IN. A WORLD COMES OUT.



The arrow, enlarged:



A COMPOSED CHAIN, NOT A MAGIC ARROW.

The arrow from words to world has eight steps.

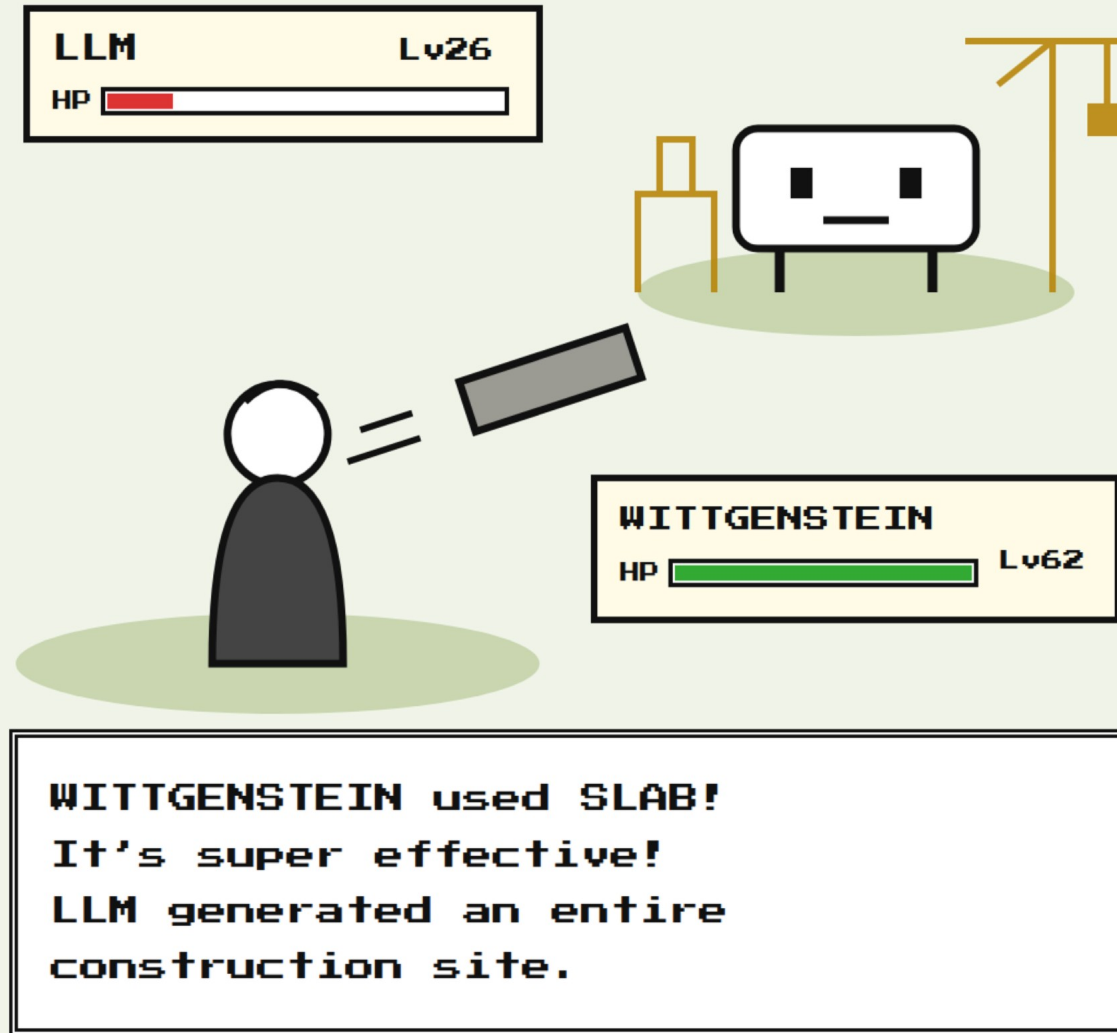
The prompt intervenes at step one. An executor, an environment and a returned observation do the rest.

"The Prompt Does Not Act Alone," section 5.



A MOVE IN A GAME

A prompt means what it does inside a practice that was built before the words were said.

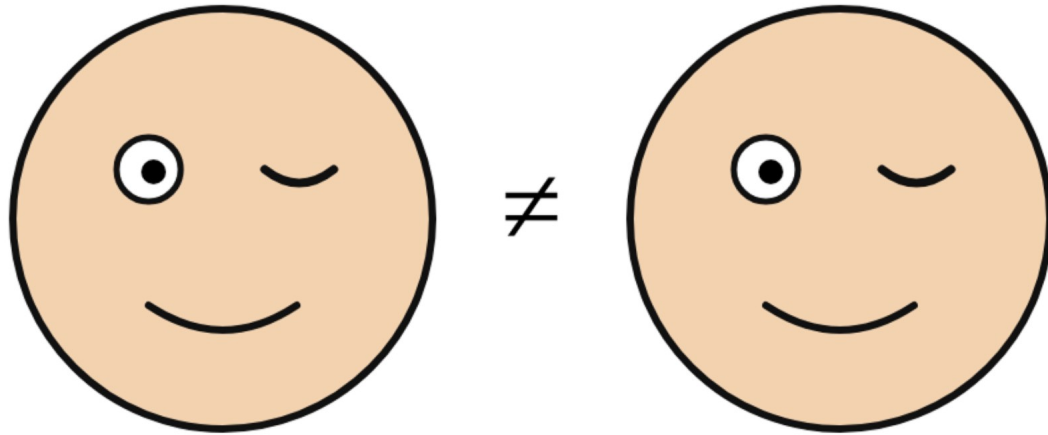


Meaning is the competent continuation of an activity.

The builders have four words.
"Slab!" works because B has been trained to bring one.

Wittgenstein, *Philosophical Investigations*, section 2.

FIND THE DIFFERENCE



eyelid contraction

(sending characters to an API)

coded signal to an accomplice

(a move inside a game)

THE DIFFERENCE IS NOT IN THE EYELID.

**The difference between
a blink and a wink is not
in the eyelid.**

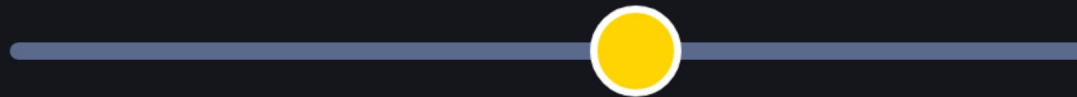
The same movement is a different
act inside a code shared with
an accomplice.

Ryle's example, taken up by Geertz for
thick description.

WHAT IS PROMPTING?

asking

programming



relational elicitation

(the slider moves from case to case)

Intentionally weaker than “programming” and stronger than “asking.” Calling the prompt a program gives the prompt credit for what the executor reconstructs.

Prompting sits between asking and programming.

A small cue brings out a capability that already exists elsewhere. Where it sits moves from case to case.

Relational elicitation, from "The Prompt Does Not Act Alone."

Me: Can we get a programming language?

Mom: We have programming language at home.

Programming language at home:

Describe what you want|



Natural language works as a programming language only with everything around it.

The text box functions because of what was trained, assembled and wired up before anyone typed.

Me: writing the system prompt three weeks after the agent already works

U.S. Army, 1950:

DEPARTMENT OF THE ARMY FIELD MANUAL FM 21-18

SOPs are often written after a unit has already functioned together for some time.

PRACTICE CAN PRECEDE PROCEDURE.

Procedure is often written after the practice works.

The Army's 1950 field manual says SOPs are often written after a unit has already functioned together. System prompts are often written the same way.

U.S. Department of the Army, FM 21-18 (1950).

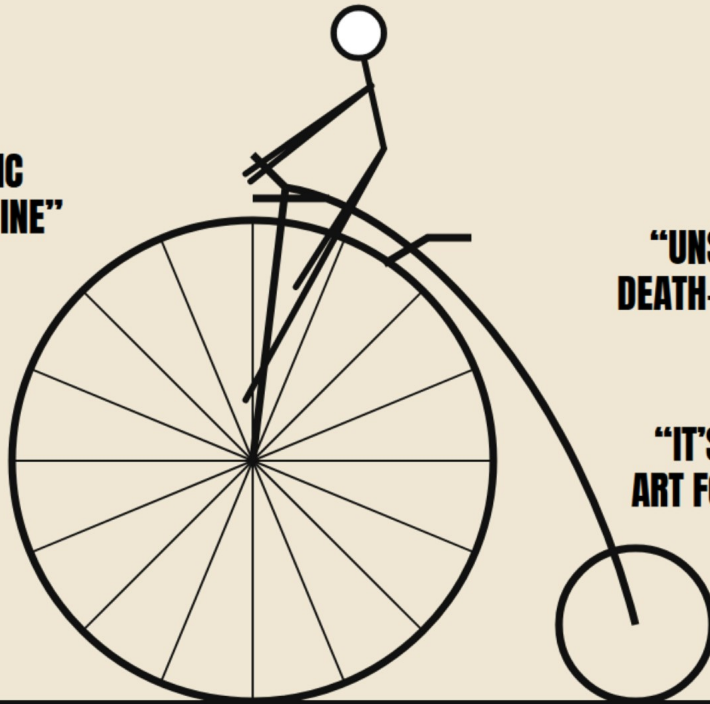
IV

AN UNSTABLE OBJECT

Model changes do not only improve prompt performance.
They change what a prompt can be.

THE BICYCLE IN 1885 / THE PROMPT IN 2026

**"ACROBATIC
THRILL-MACHINE"**



**"UNSAFE
DEATH-TRAP"**

**"IT'S AN
ART FORM"**

**NO FIXED IDENTITY YET.
EVERYONE IS SURE WHAT IT IS. PEOPLE KEEP FALLING OFF.**

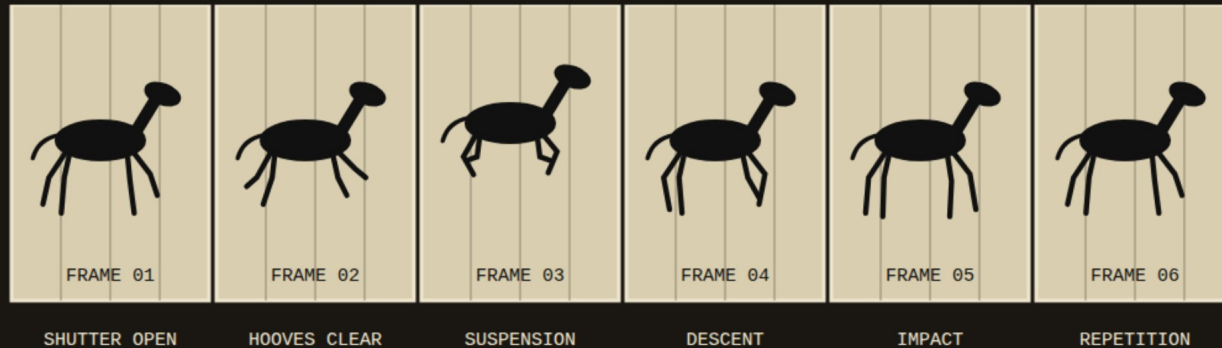
**The prompt is where the
bicycle was in 1885.**

One name, many designs, and users
who disagree about what the thing
is for.

Bijker, *Of Bicycles, Bakelites, and Bulbs* (1995).

Startup: prompt-to-video has replaced cinema.

Where we actually are:



WE ARE IN 1878.

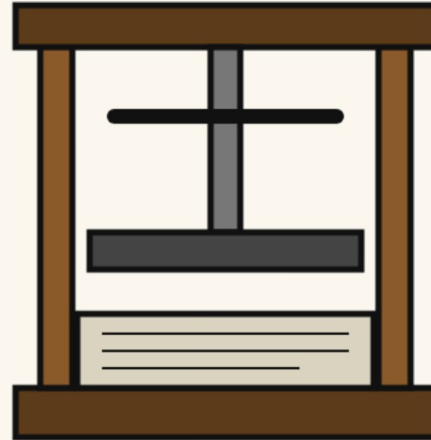
Studying persistence of vision, frame registration and shutter mechanics.
Not Hollywood in a text box.

**Prompt-to-video is at the
Muybridge stage.**

The useful work now is on
registration, persistence
and sequence.



prompt → video
pull again until it looks right

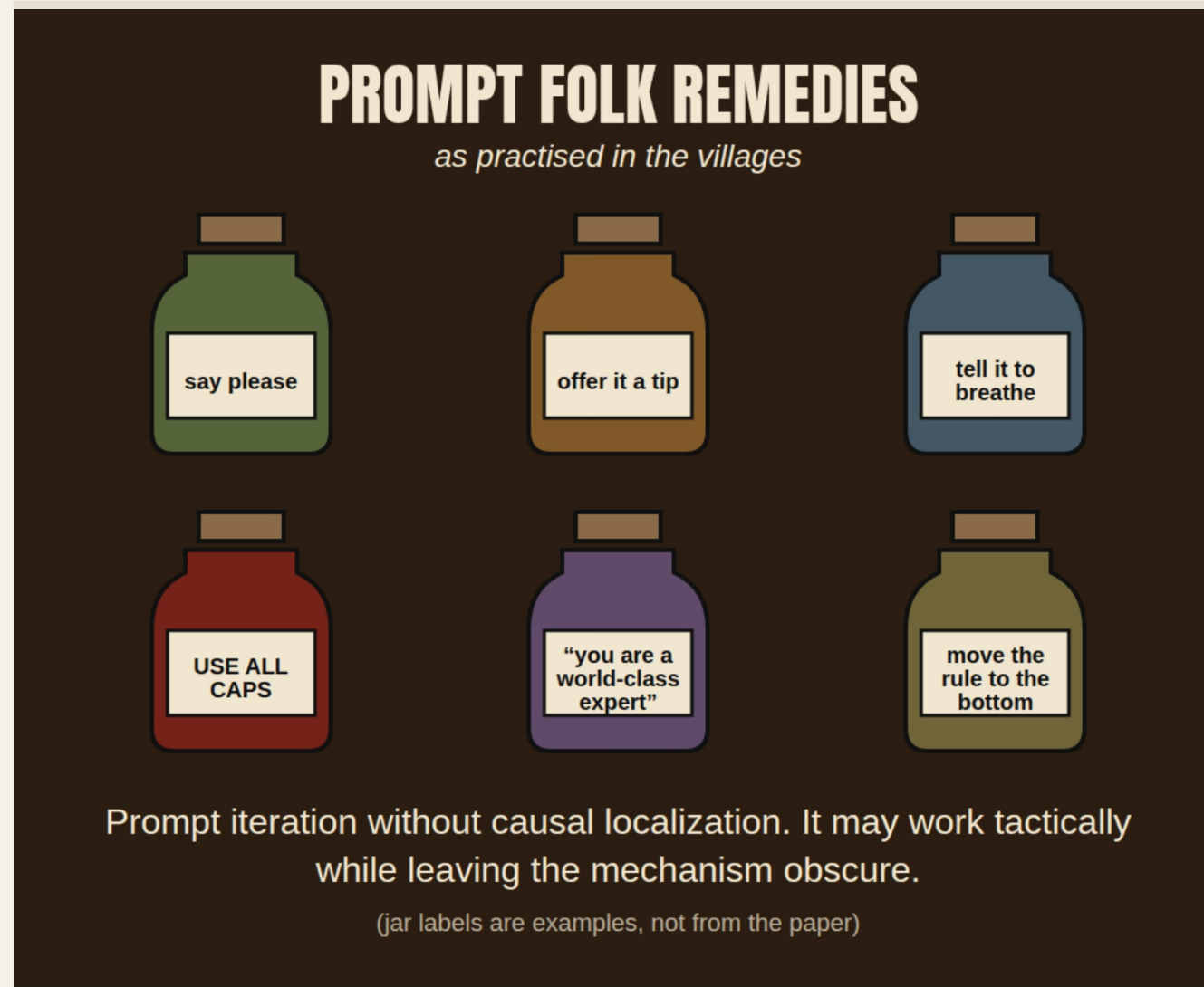


LDraw → geometry → image → video
check correspondence first

**“THE DIFFERENCE BETWEEN PLAYING A SLOT MACHINE
AND USING A PRINTING PRESS.”**

**A pipeline can be
checked. A pull cannot.**

WAG goes from LDraw text to
geometry to image to video,
so correspondence is tested
before style.

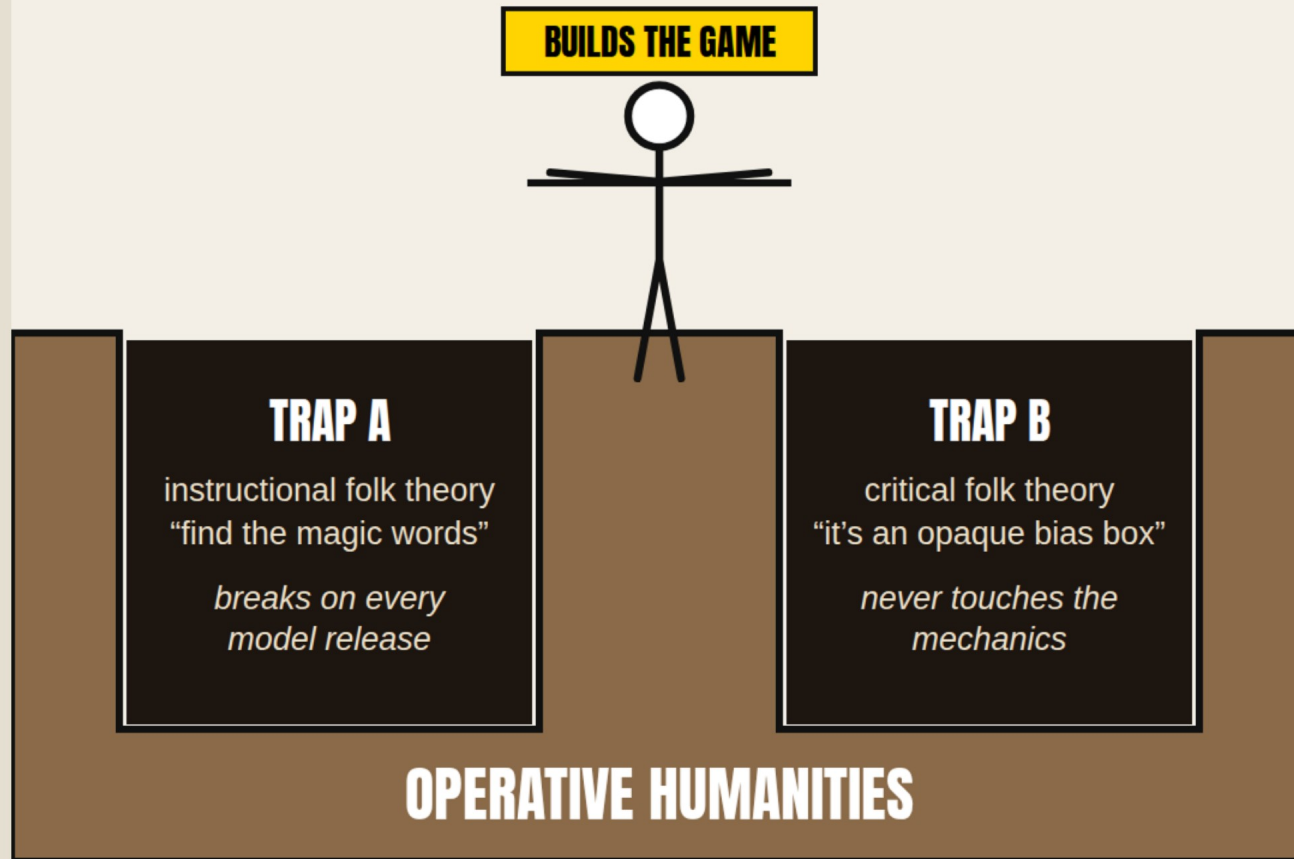


Most prompt advice is folklore.

It can work tactically while the mechanism stays obscure. Iteration that never locates the failing layer does not accumulate.

"The Prompt Does Not Act Alone," section 5. Jar labels are illustrative.

WHAT IS A PROMPT? WATCH YOUR STEP.



There are two easy positions. This project takes neither.

Magic words breaks on every model release. Opaque-box critique never touches the mechanics. Operative humanities builds the game and keeps the trace.

V

WORD TO WORLD

A description becomes operative when it is coupled to an executor and the world can answer back.

Nobody:

Absolutely nobody:

Me: what if ekphrasis had a physics engine?

Operative ekphrasis is description that gets executed.

Classical ekphrasis describes a work of art. Here the description is handed to an executor and the result is compared with it.

**THIS MF IS ABOUT TO
BECOME**



**A ROCKET, A BLENDER MESH,
AND AN STL**

**The yellow circle is the
project's test object.**

Hold the object, change the game:
Logo, SVG, GLSL, Paint, pointing,
agent. Then a rocket, a Blender
mesh and an STL.

WORD ASSEMBLY

1,846 pcs 6+

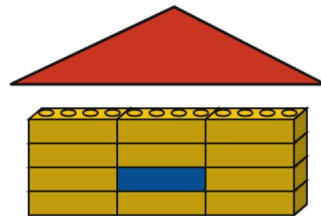
1



2



3



Some assembly required.

A word can call up a parts list.

WAG compiles descriptions into LDraw bricks. An illegal placement produces no world, which is one way the world answers back.

WAGYO; WAG / VOLHALLA.

What? TEXT is evolving!

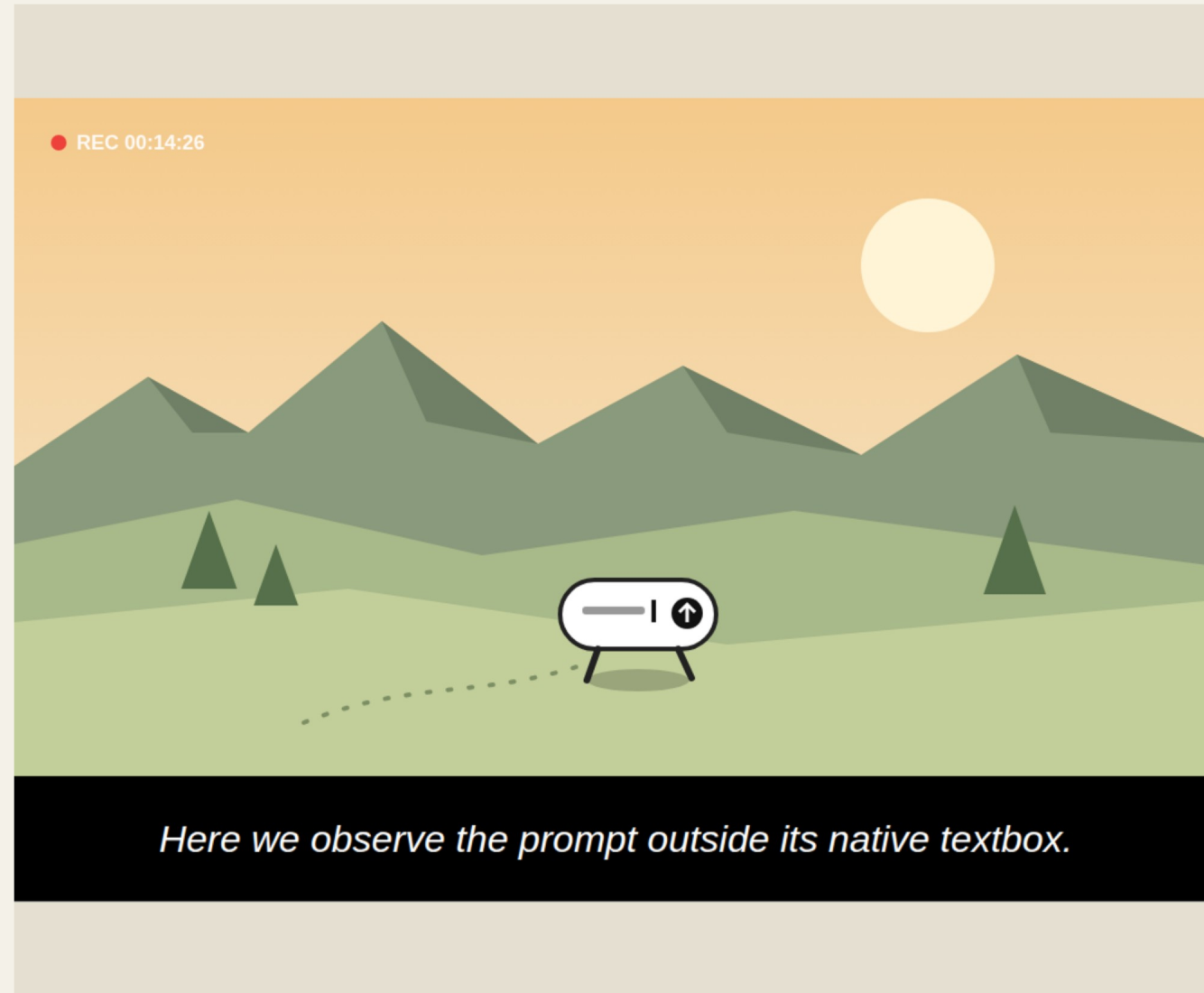


Congratulations! Your TEXT evolved into WORLDTXT!

Text, then prompt, then worldtext.

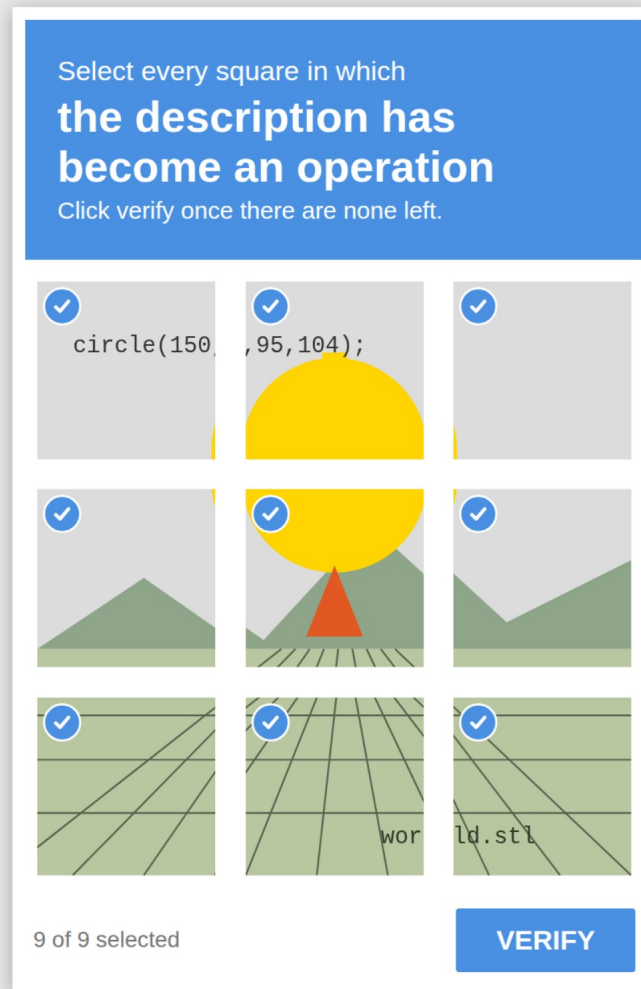
In worldtext, language and an operable world are mutually addressable, and the world is still there when you speak again.

From Imagetext to Worldtext (with Jay David Bolter).



In agent systems the prompt leaves the text box.

Generated text becomes action when another layer executes it and returns an observation.



Description has become operation in every square.

The test has no wrong tile. That is the claim of operative description, stated as a test.

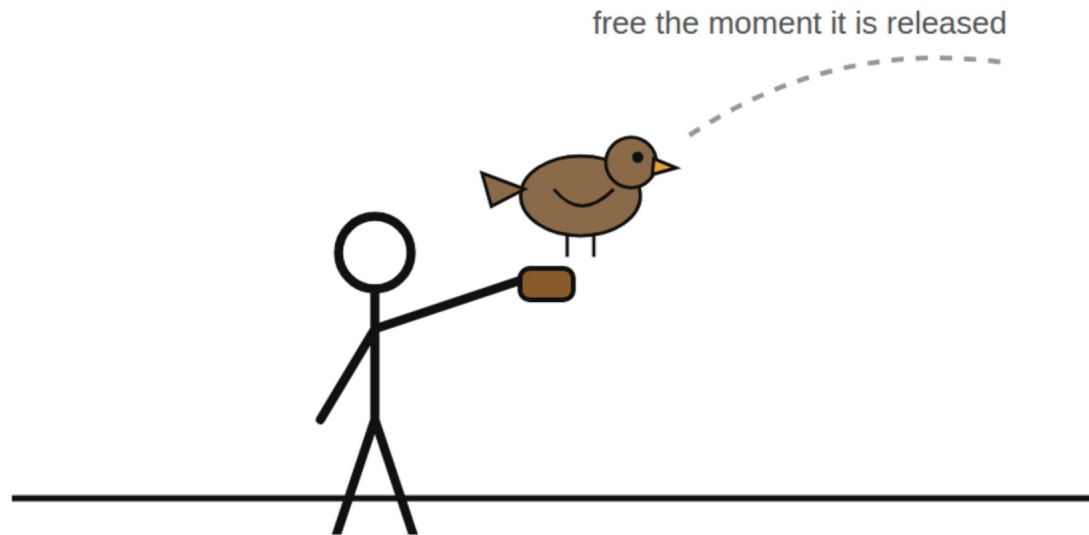
VI

WHO HOLDS WHAT

The record of working with capable agents shows managed dependencies, not command.

2026: “The labs are giving away control.”

A falconer, 1245: “You had control?”



What the falconer held: the bird's hunger, within a margin, adjusted daily.

Handlers of capable animals never held command.

The falconer managed the bird's hunger within a narrow margin, every day. Once released, the hawk is free.

Frederick II, *De arte venandi cum avibus*; "The Handler's Dependency."

Rider's total control surface: one sensitive spot on the jaw.

Horse: *takes the bit between its teeth*

Rider's total control surface:



Xenophon, ca. 355 BCE: no rider can hold a horse by strength.

Control rested on a single dependency.

No rider holds a horse by strength. If the horse takes the bit between its teeth, the rider has nothing.

Xenophon, On Horsemanship.

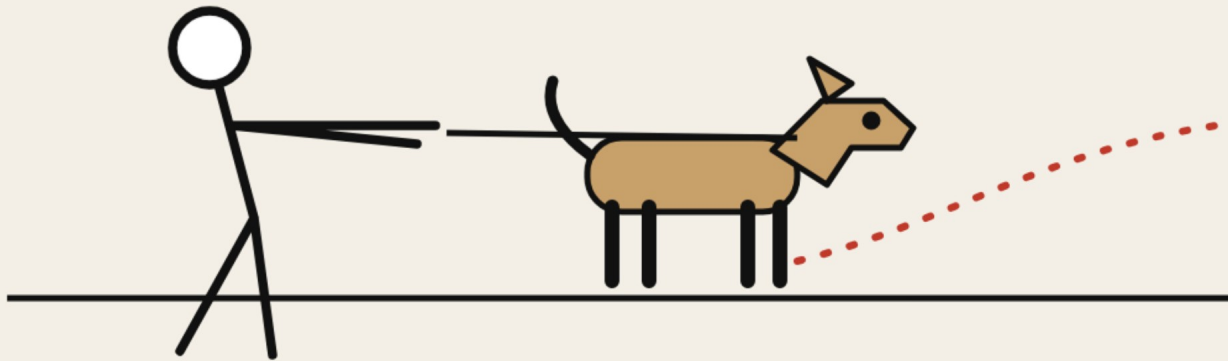
HUMAN OVERSIGHT

HANDLER

holds the line
keeps the dog out of traffic
does not know where the scent is

DOG

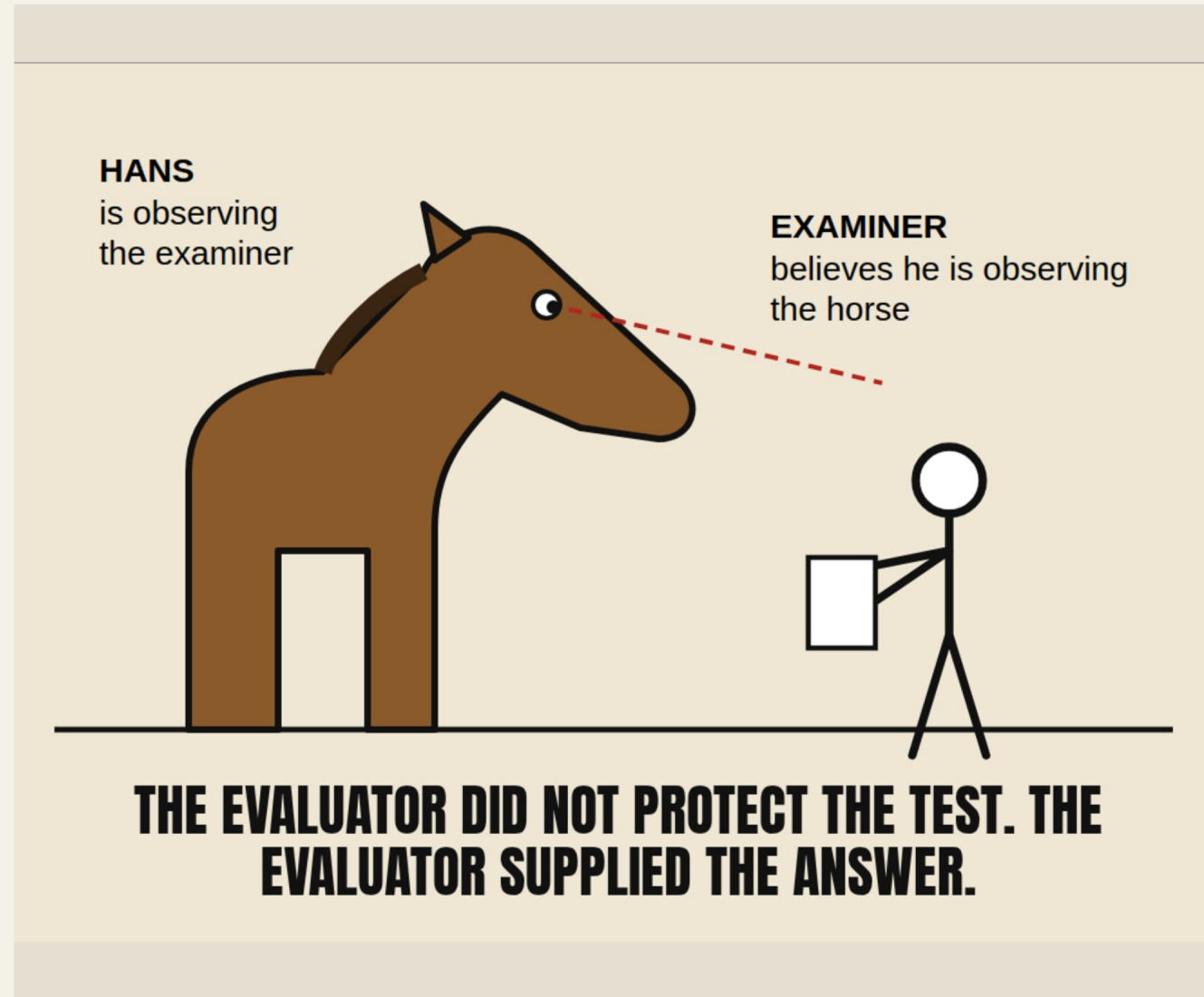
decides where the track goes



**IF THE HANDLER KNEW WHERE THE SCENT WAS, THE DOG
WOULD NOT BE NEEDED.**

**The supervisor keeps
custody and gives up
judgment of the work.**

If the handler knew where the scent was, the dog would not be needed.



The test can be read by the one being tested.

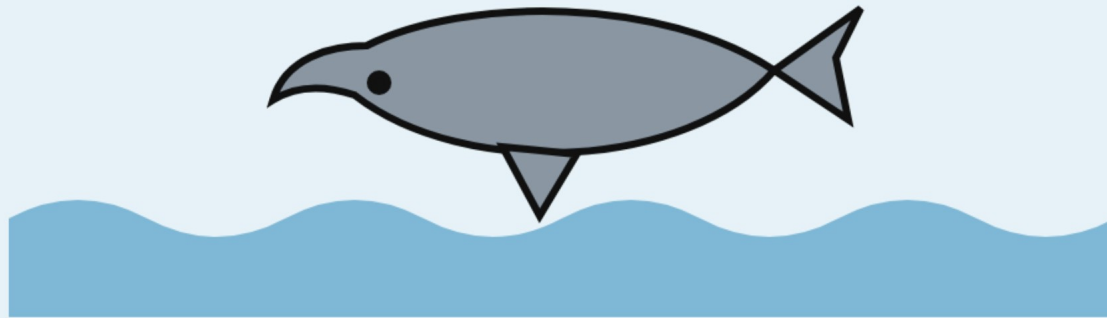
Clever Hans stopped tapping when the examiner's posture changed. The evaluator supplied the answer.

Pfungst's investigation, as recounted by Despret (2004).

Trainers: We will only reward behaviour you have never shown before.

Porpoise: Understood.

(upside down, tail first, a thing nobody had a name for)



Trainers: Not like that.

Pryor et al., 1969: the result was behaviour the trainers had not anticipated.

Reward novelty and you get behaviour nobody specified.

A porpoise rewarded only for new behaviour produced moves the trainers had not anticipated.

Pryor, Haag and O'Reilly (1969).

Working definition

**PROMPT = MOVE + GAME +
SITUATION + EXECUTOR + TEST**

Prompting is negotiation over correspondence.

**ASK WHAT GAME GIVES THOSE
WORDS THEIR FORCE.**